



Bet You Didn't Know

Digital Push

A problem that you may have faced quite often is the difficulty in clicking good, sharp images in dim light. Digital photography provides a solution: the digital push. Use this technique with regular shots as well as high-zoom shots, or macros.

Essentially, if you are in doubt whether the light is sufficient, set a higher shutter speed, and later augment the photograph on a PC.

The problem is that in low-light conditions, you need more exposure, and hence a slower shutter speed. This can be problematic if you have shaky hands—camera jitter can ruin a low-light, slow-shutter-speed photo. To overcome this, offload the brightness aspect to the PC. Just use a higher shutter speed, and enhance the image digitally. Several software, many of which come bundled with digital cameras, help you do that. You can adjust brightness, gamma, contrast, and other settings.

your sports photography without flash as far as possible.

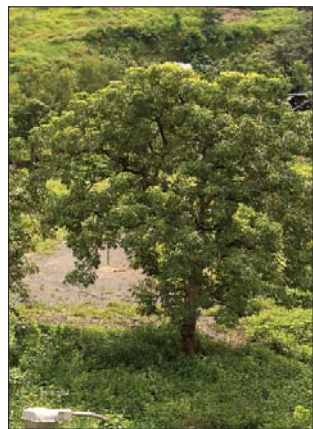
☐ Speed is of the essence here. Try buying several smaller memory cards instead of one large one. This is because larger memory cards take up more resources—and time—while 'searching' for a location to store.

White Balance



Different light sources illuminate objects differently. Halogen bulbs, for example, produce a yellow or orange colour cast.

Fluorescent lamps may result in a greenish cast. Set the White-Balance on the camera, if your source of illumination is not the flash or daylight. Alternatively, you can let it White-Balance automatically. In a nutshell, White-Balance is the method used to colour-correct light sources other than flash or daylight, so that the light appears correct. White-Balance forces the brightest parts of the image to appear pure white. These brightest parts are often indeed white, but appear as some other shade if White-Balance is not used. Basically, White-Balance dictates what is white and what is not. Note, also, that photographs come out different when you use automatic White Balance as against using the features of the camera to do it manually. The photos alongside illustrate this



This picture was shot manually adjusting the White Balance using the features on the digicam...

difference—the first photograph was White-Balanced for cloudiness. Here again, you will need to experiment.

Indoors/Outdoors



The ideal lighting for indoor and outdoor photography is different. For example, indoors, a flash serves to light up objects, whereas outdoors, it serves to fill in shadows.

☐ Daylight and artificial light have different 'colour temperatures', and give different lighting effects and hues. Avoid mixing the two. Also, different sources have different effects—halogen lamps cast a yellow hue, while incandescent bulbs produce a bluish tint. So, experiment with indoor lighting.

☐ Most cameras come with an inbuilt red-eye reduction feature. However, this involves what is called a 'pre-flash', which might cause the subject to blink. To avoid this,



...while here, the White Balancing was done by the camera. Note the difference in naturalness of shade

turn on a light somewhere at a distance to reduce the effect of the pre-flash on the subject. You can also redirect the flash so it doesn't fall directly onto the subject's face. Yet another solution is to diffuse the flash by pasting some translucent tracing paper over it.

☐ Use a bounce flash to get natural, diffused light that highlights features evenly. You can do this by placing a mirror at a 45-degree angle in front of the flash, to reflect the flash off the ceiling.

☐ If your subjects are in a room, opt for light-coloured ceilings and walls, as this tends to diffuse light.

☐ Outdoors is a different story: The subject is already well-lit. You have to take care of other things. For example, it is often best to click with your back to the Sun. However, an LCD screen is difficult to see in bright sunlight. Hence, try and get a digital camera that has a viewfinder in addition to the LCD screen.

☐ In bright daylight, use the flash to fill in shadows. Imagine a scene where the subject is backlit by, say, a setting sun; if you don't use the flash here, the subject will appear as a dark silhouette.

☐ Extreme temperatures can damage your digicam. Do not leave it too long in direct sunlight. Cover it with light-coloured or reflective material.

☐ Outdoors isn't really a good testbed for digicams. Consider a tree: if your camera has a million pixels, and the tree has a few lakh leaves, then that translates to about two or



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it's unbelievable!

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